

often predominated. The bounty money offered for volunteering and the money paid for substitutes were considerable sums to ordinary working men. Even without cheating the system—it was not too difficult to enlist several times for the bounty and evade the service—a man could feel well-off with the one-time payment. Late in the war immigrants arriving in the United States were often enlisted straight off the boat, some having embarked on the voyage specifically to sign up.

“I hope and trust that strength will be given to me to stand and do my duty.”

PRIVATE EDWARD EDES, LETTER TO HIS FATHER, APRIL 1863

Improving morale

Loyalty to his colleagues and proud identification with his regiment, brigade, and corps were the bonds that held a man in place and, more than any other factor, made him ready to fight. Although obedience never came easily, the Union army developed into a reasonably well-drilled and disciplined force, with order enforced by harsh corporal punishments. From 1862 onward, Union troops were generally well supplied and equipped. Northern factories provided sufficient standard uniforms and footwear, even if sometimes of poor quality, and the official food ration was quite generous in its portions of bacon, beef, bread, and beans. But men easily became ragged and hungry during hard campaigning. Even when the supply system had not broken down, the temptation to pillage farms along the line of march, usually in Confederate territory, was rarely resisted. When marching, endurance was required—the pack was heavy, feet were sore—but even in a well supplied camp the military routines could be both boring and wearing. Disease was a serious threat, especially in the early period before sanitation